Auto-AdvER Annotation Guidelines

Below are the annotation guidelines used for the Auto-AdvER study, along with the sub-entities identified for each label, followed by the themes that were considered but deliberately excluded from annotation.

Condition — Current State

The `CONDITION` category covers any information about the vehicle that is current as of the date the advertisement was posted.

Definition

The `CONDITION` label identifies any word or span of words in car advertisements that indicate the present material or documented condition of the vehicle, both positive and negative. This includes descriptions that reflect the car's current operational performance, mechanical state, aesthetic appearance, maintenance status, and legal classifications affecting its value or usability.

These include:

- Tyre condition (i.e. trim level or mention of good condition)
- Interior condition (e.g., "leather like new")
- Exterior condition (e.g., "presence of scratches")
- Mechanical condition (e.g., "engine noise", "gear not locking properly")
- MoT[1] due date or recently completed MoT mentioned
- Service due date or recently completed service mentioned
- Current mileage (e.g., "12k miles")
- Cat S, C, D or N[2]
- Registered, pre-registered, non-registered, demonstrator[3]

[1]This refers to the Ministry of Transport, which, in a broader context, represents any legal authority responsible for ensuring vehicle safety by enforcing compliance with minimum standards.

[2]This refers to vehicle categories (such as Cat S, C, D, or N), which, in a broader context, denote classifications used by insurance companies and authorities in the UK to indicate vehicles that have sustained damage and have subsequently been repaired or written off.

[3]This refers to vehicle registration statuses (such as registered, pre-registered, non-registered, or demonstrator), which, in a broader context, indicate whether a vehicle has been officially recorded with authorities, previously assigned registration by a dealership, remains unregistered, or has been used primarily for demonstration purposes.

Annotation span length and methodology

1. A condition span is typically characterised by the noun of a part of a vehicle (e.g., "tyre thread") and an attribute that links to it (e.g., "low"). The whole phrase is annotated (e.g., "tyre thread is low"), and anything else is omitted.
2. Opinion-based statements are disregarded, such as "low mileage", since it denotes an opinion that the car is of low mileage for its age; instead "80,000 mileage" is labelled, since it is presented as a fact. Likewise, "amazing condition" does not add enough valuable information to the advert, being opinion, whereas "clean paintwork" is specific and adds value, so the second is labelled but not the first.
3. Span words referring to the state of the vehicle at the time the advert was posted are labelled, e.g., "6 month MoT", "80,000 miles"; references to doing extra miles after the advert was posted can safely be ignored.

Historic — Events in the Past

The `HISTORIC` attribute covers events that occurred before the car advertisement was posted.

Definition

The `HISTORIC` label identifies any word or span of words in car advertisements that present events or details from the vehicle's past that have affected its mechanical condition or bodywork.

These include:

- Mention of past accidents (e.g., "3 years back I scratched the front side")
- Number of owners
  - Solely, without mentioning "from new". E.g., "3 owners ~~from new~~"
- Past type of usage
  - Any mention of past usage that could affect its condition, either positive or negative. E.g., "smoke free", "motorway mileage", "stored in locked garage"
- Component change (e.g., "Cambelt changed a year ago", "New brake calipers", "new tyres, brake discs") and tuning (e.g., "re-mapping")
- MoT advisories, or no advisories, mentioned
- HPI[4] is clear (as opposed to only offering an HPI report as a Sales Option, see below)
- Service history done in the past, including stamps (e.g., 8 stamps), dates (e.g., "02/203, 01/2024")[5] or mileages (e.g., "@ 30k, @40k, @49k") and where (e.g., "BMW")

Annotation span length and methodology

1. The annotation span under Historic can be considered the most elaborate of the three classes. It refers to events that happened in the past (e.g., "Replaced clutch", "3 owners", "Last service was done 3,000 miles ago", "primarily done on the motorway").

[4]This refers to Hire Purchase Investigation, which, in a broader context, denotes a vehicle history check commonly used in the UK to verify whether a vehicle has outstanding finance, has been reported stolen, previously written off, or has other hidden issues.

[5]Reproduced verbatim from the source guidelines; ambiguous between 02/2003 and 02/2023.

2. Should there be a mention of damage and subsequently a relevant mention of component change, these are two separate spans. Each bullet point above is treated as a separate span.
3. If a span mentions a component change that still reflects the present, it is labelled as Historic (e.g., "2 new front tyres fitted last May").

Sales Options

`SALES_OPTIONS` covers aspects related to the selling process itself.

Definition

The `SALES_OPTIONS` label refers to any word or span of words that indicates something tangible or a service offered during or after the sale, apart from the car itself, that enhances the sale proposition.

These include:

- Part exchange offers
- Number of keys
- Delivery & delivery options
- Extended opening times (i.e. unusual times, late night or weekends)
- Warranty available
- Financing options
- Sale of the car's licence plate (or not)
- Availability of additional photos from past accidents
- Offering a test drive
- Price negotiability
- Any documentation, e.g.:
  - Full service history logbook (FSH)
  - Providing MoT papers
- Valeting / cleaning
- Any other kind of service that could be considered an advantage over other sellers

Annotation span length and methodology

1. The noun part of the sale, or any adjective specifying it, is labelled, disregarding any conditions attached to it. For instance, "2 year warranty ~~when financed with Volvo Services, Terms and Conditions apply~~".
2. Spans that add value to the advert, according to annotator judgment, are labelled. If something resembles a Sales Option but adds no value compared with the rest of the advert, it is disregarded; contact details and location are instances of this.

Not Tracked Entities

The following recurrent themes were identified during annotation but deliberately excluded, with the reasons recorded:

- **Logistical costs**: tax, insurance, ULEZ[6] compliance, and how long a full tank lasts — redundant, since these are calculable more accurately from the car's specification, purchase time, location and type of use.
- **Personal sentiments**: statements of emotional distress about selling the car (e.g., "it breaks my heart to see this car go") — omitted as they add nothing to an objective, quantifiable metric.
- **Reason for selling**: e.g., buying a newer vehicle, downsizing — omitted for the same reason.
- **Car identifiables**: brand, model, year, colour and engine size re-stated in the free text — omitted as redundant with the advert header, where this information already appears.
- **Invitation for communication & location**: references to contacting the seller or to where the vehicle is located — not labelled.
- **Optional & standard features**: of clear interest, since features can change a vehicle's price evaluation, but what counts as a feature differs from vehicle to vehicle and manufacturer to manufacturer. A separate piece of work targets feature annotation against a per-vehicle catalogue, cast as a contextual entity-recognition problem.
- **Sales pitch**: elaborate descriptions, more common among traders than individual sellers, that emphasise a vehicle's appeal without substantive factual content.

[6]The acronym refers to the Ultra Low Emission Zone charge in London, where more polluting vehicles are charged accordingly.